PHOTOGRAPHS BY IWG

IWG Chairman Joe Laird in action

Shining a light on the IWG

Eugene Grimley and **Peter Lyons** recall the early days of the Irish Woodturners' Guild and how it evolved to become what it is today

The Irish Woodturners' Guild – IWG – was founded in 1983 making it the oldest such organisation in the world. In 1980 Liam O'Neill and Ciaran Forbes had attended the International Woodturning Seminar at the John Makepeace School for Craftsmen in Wood at Parnham House, Dorset, England. At this event they met David Ellsworth, Bob Stockdale, Stephen Hogbin, Ray Key and Richard Raffan. Inspired, Liam O'Neill decided to put on a similar event in Ireland, which he achieved in 1982 with Ray Key and Phil Reardon supporting him as the main demonstrators.

This, in turn, led to Liam O'Neill, Ciaran Forbes, Jim Foley, Willie Stedmond and others forming the Irish Woodturners' Guild in 1983. The idea was to set up a national, non-profit-making organisation dedicated to the advancement and promotion of woodturning and within a year there were upwards of 100 members representing almost every county in Ireland. The IWG was open to turners of all abilities from hobbyist to professional and from the outset it was an all-Ireland body.

The Guild's first seminar was held at Shannon, County Clare, in September 1983 with Ray Key, Michael and Liz O'Donnell and Richard Raffan as the guest demonstrators. Its success gave the then committee of the IWG the confidence to press ahead with more ambitious plans, which included having an annual seminar.

At the 1984 event David Ellsworth joined Michael and Liz O'Donnell and a great number of talented Irish turners. It was David Ellsworth's experience of these early woodturning seminars that inspired him to set up the American Association of Woodturners in 1986 and the following year Ray Key established the Association of Woodturners of Great Britain.

Chapters

In 1985, regional seminars were organised and this eventually led to the formation of local 'Chapters', a structure that still exists within the IWG. Members join the Guild and a proportion of the membership fee is returned to their 'home' Chapter to assist in its running costs. This is one of the main strengths of the IWG with a strong, open-minded, national organisation providing guidance and support for the local Chapters.

The first Chapter of the IWG was set up in Dublin in 1990 and it this group that adopted the title 'Chapter' rather than 'branch' or 'club', following the lead of the American Association of Woodturners. The aim of the Chapters was to build on the woodturning skills of their members and to provide a local forum for the interchange of ideas. This process continues today and there are now some 20 Chapters across Ireland.

A new Chapter can be established by 10 members of the IWG applying to the National Executive Committee. Following its approval, the new Chapter will get a formation grant from the IWG and set up a committee to organise the activities of the Chapter. Most Chapters hold a monthly meeting, which usually takes the form of a demonstration by one of their own members or by a turner from outside the Chapter, sometimes even from outside Ireland.

A typical small Chapter

The Crossborder Chapter was formed in 2007 with about 40 members, although this susequently fell back to the current figure of about 30 members. Early meetings were held in the woodwork room of Beechill College in Monaghan but during redevelopment at the school the Chapter was obliged to find

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